

Geography of Colombian Life Satisfaction

Sunday 26th April, 2026 15:02

XXX TODO ADD TO EBIB AS KEYWORD PAPER-CODE-NAME AND TAG WITH EBIB KEYWORDS

This paper is about geography of Colombian happiness.¹ We start with departments/provinces, then move to cities/municipalities, and finally finish up with urban-rural and farmers.

about colombia boilerplate like 2nd biggest land mas and pop in lat am? one of the happiest in the world:

Table 1: 10 happiest countries in the world. Data from World Database of Happiness (WDH) 2010-2019 out of 160 countries at worlddatabaseofhappiness.eur.nl/rank-reports/satisfaction-with-life; and World Values Surveys (WVS) 2005-2022 [waves 5-7] out of 88 countries at <https://www.worldvaluessurvey.org>. Technical information for WDH is at <http://worlddatabaseofhappiness.eur.nl/reports/finding-reports-on-happiness-in-nations/technical-details-to-rank-reports-of-happiness-in-nations/technical-details-to-rank-report-average-happiness-in-nations-2010-2019> and WVS documentation is at <https://www.worldvaluessurvey.org/WVSDocumentationWV7.jsp>.

WDH			WVS		
rank	country	happiness (1-10)	rank	country	happiness (1-10)
1	Denmark	8.2	1	Puerto Rico	8.4
2	Mexico	8.1	2	Mexico	8.3
3	Colombia	8.1	3	Colombia	8.3
4	Switzerland	8	4	Qatar	8.0
5	Finland	8	5	Norway	7.9
6	Iceland	8	6	Nicaragua	7.9
7	Costa Rica	7.9	7	Tajikistan	7.9
8	Norway	7.9	8	Switzerland	7.9
9	Canada	7.9	9	Uzbekistan	7.9
10	Qatar	7.8	10	Ecuador	7.8

and need about geography like goog 'gepgraphy of colombia' in goog scholar and normal goog

about roads etc ranked one of thw worst and airports

We know little about colombian happiness: my paper, stiupid burger as cited in my paper, and that govt report i cite in my paper!! do skim thru it!!

1 Data

We use a great source of data ECV. We use 2023 edition.

The life satisfaction item reads: ??

¹Following usual practice in social indicators research terms happiness and life satisfaction are used interhchangeably, and specifically we mean cognitive and evaluative life satisfaction rather than affective happiness.

2 Departments/Provinces

there are 166k missing out of 242k, we conduct robustness check in appendix using 2021 wave

the map is below, table including number of observations per province is in appendix

unhappy: West (poor Choco, and Southern Cauca and Narino) and East Guainia and Vichada. In 2021 (see appendix) Choco and Cauca were still relatively unhappy, but slightly happier.

Happy caffetero: Caldas, Risaralda, Quindio—in 2021 there were slight differences (see appendix) but overall Caffetero was happy too. And also happy Santander. Then slightly less happy Norte de Santander, Cesar and Atlantico. In 2021 (see appendix) Santander, Cesar and Atlantico were less happy.

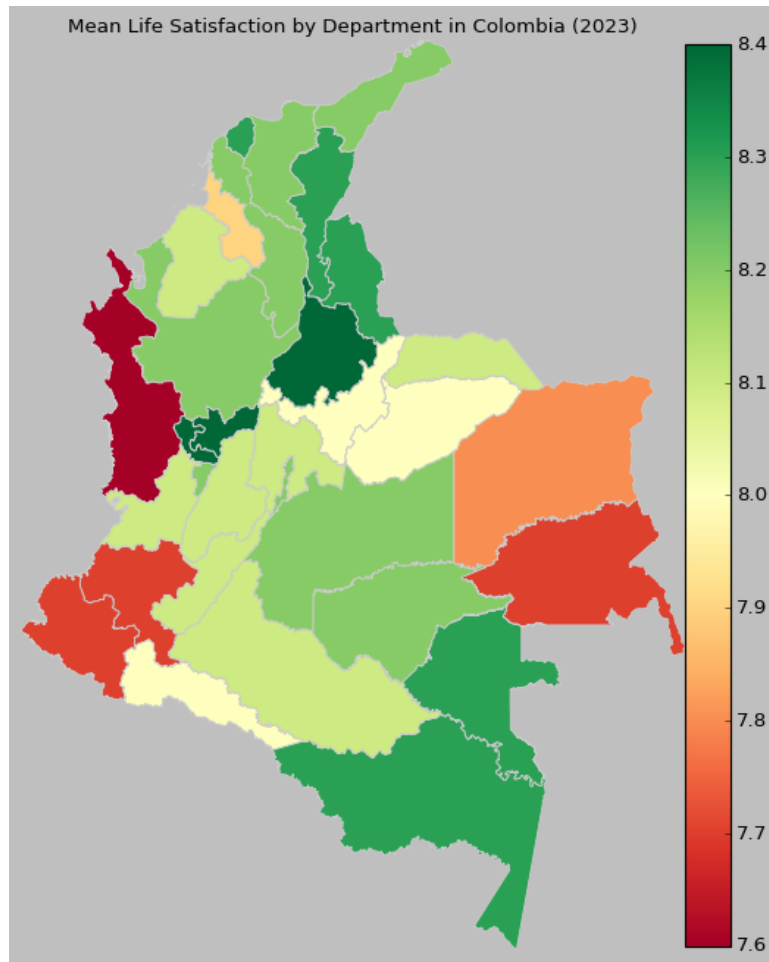


Figure 1: Similar to 2021 robustness/sensitivity check in appendix except: small sample Amazonas and Vaupés, both South-Eastern at 8.3 in 2023 v 7.6 in 2021, a .7 difference. Second largest differences: Santander and Putumayo increased by .4 from 2021 to 2023.

3 Cities/Municipalities

166k/242k missing, again robustness/sensitivity check in appendix with 2021 ecv

Acacias	8.3
Aguazul	8.1
Armenia	8.1
Barrancabermeja	8.6
Barranquilla	8.3
Bogotá, D.C.	8.2
Bucaramanga	8.6
Buenaventura	8.1
Calarcá	8.4
Cali	8.0
Cartagena	8.2
Ciénaga	8.4
Cúcuta	8.3
Florencia	8.2
Ibagué	8.4
Malambo	8.3
Manizales	8.4
Medellín	8.4
Montería	8.3
Neiva	8.3
Palmira	7.9
Pasto	7.9
Pereira	8.4
Pitalito	8.0
Popayán	7.9
Puerto Carreño	7.5
San José del Guaviare	8.1
Santa Marta	8.3
Sincelejo	8.1
Sogamoso	8.2
Tuluá	8.2
Tunja	7.9
Valledupar	8.0
Villavicencio	8.2
Yopal	8.3

Figure 2

Santander is one of the happiest departments, and so 2 santander largest cities shine: Bucaramanga and Barrancabermeja at 8.6. Bucaramanga was less happy in 2021 at 8.1. Another happy region coffeeero has many happy cities: Calarcá, Pereira, Manizales, and Armenia (Armenia was even happier in 2021). Other happy cities include 2nd largest Medellín, Ibagué, and Ciénaga (Ciénaga was less happy in 2021 at 7.9). The least happy is remote Western Puerto Carreño at 7.5, and several cities at 7.9: Tunja, and Southern cities: Palmira in Valle de Cauca, Popayán in Cauca, and Pasto in Narino.

4 Urban-Rural and Farmers

While most developed countries cities are unhappy and indeed unhappy city is a common pattern across the world (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2021), it is not always the case in developing countries.

here boilerplate from happy col unahhpy bog: that cities are growth engines Glaeser (2011) and O'Sullivan (2009) and developing countries like colombia do need economic growth hence role for cities is greataer than in already develpd countries

and there is paradox of happy peasant and unhappy millionaire Graham (2009)

though not so much in colombia, urban and rural are about same happy, except by income: bar chart by income category bu urb rur as in raman

Both rural and farmer in figures ?? ??—there are slight differences, but overall similar pattern—no difference for the bottom and 9th deciles; rural and farmer happier in 2nd-8th deciles, and urban happier in the top decile. This makes sense, one needs money to enjoy city, where costof living is higher. In addition, life is more commodified in the city—one needs to pay for more things. For instance, many in the rural areas grow their own food. The bottom decile parity could be explained as that there is some minimum income necessary, and below it, it doesnt help to live in rural v urban area.

Overall, it is worth emphasizing that except the 1st decile and up to median and one decile above it—farmers/rural clearly happier.

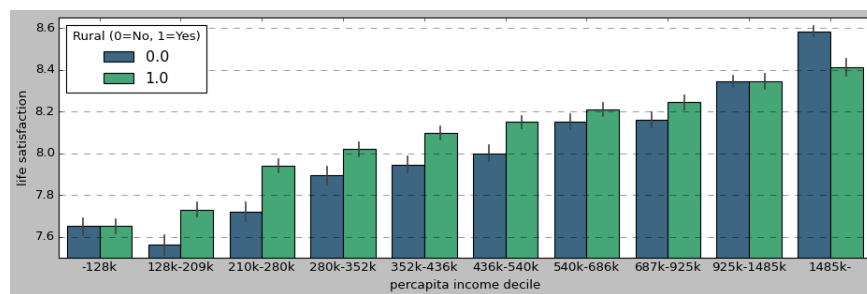


Figure 3

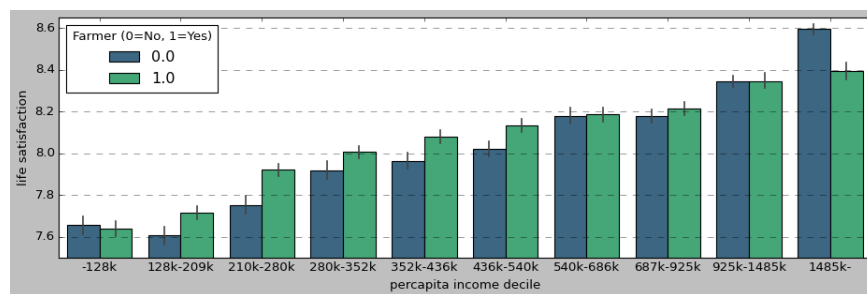


Figure 4

ONLINE APPENDIX (Supplementary Online Material (SOM))

[note: this section will NOT be a part of the final version of the manuscript, but will be available online instead]

```
. tabstat ls, by(lwd7) stat(mean sd) format(%9.1f)
```

Summary for variables: ls
Group variable: lwd7 (RECODE of lwd (do what you like))

lwd7	Mean	SD
0-4	5.6	2.7
2	7.6	2.3
3	7.6	1.8
4	8.0	1.5
5	7.8	1.9
6	8.2	1.5
7	8.9	1.5
Total	8.3	1.9

.9

5 Reestimation Using 2023 ECV

2021 May be biased say bc of covid, especially that it peaked in colombia in 2021 <https://coronavirus.jhu.edu/region/colombia>(by 2023 used in the paper it pretty much cleared). But it a useful robustness check, if covid didnt change much , then it should be pretty stable

and it was quite high mortality in col <https://coronavirus.jhu.edu/data/mortality>

5.1 Departments/Provinces

Again as said in the paper, overall results are similar to 2023 reported in the body of the paper, except small sample Amazonas and Vaupés, both South-Eastern and with 8.3 in 2023 v 7.6 in 2021, a .7 difference. Sencond largest differences are for Santander and Putumayo which increased by .4 from 2021 to 2023.

Table 2: Life satisfaction by department.

department	life isfaction 2023	sat- total 2023	obs	non- missing life satisfaction 2023	mean life satisfaction 2021	total 2021	obs	non ing satisfaction 2021	miss- life	2023-2021
Amazonas	8.3	276		245	7.6	423		365		0.7
Antioquia	8.2	5499		4729	8.3	6036		5060		-0.1
Arauca	8.1	974		773	8.1	1103		868		0
Atlántico	8.3	3144		2311	8.0	2338		1799		0.3
Bogotá, D.C.	8.2	4688		3446	8.1	5337		3810		0.1
Bolívar	8.2	2584		2258	8.1	2495		2156		0.1
Boyacá	8.0	4129		3649	7.8	4638		4122		0.2
Caldas	8.4	2822		2555	8.2	3335		3005		0.2
Caquetá	8.1	2547		2018	7.9	2846		2249		0.2
Casanare	8.0	1749		1370	8.1	2051		1457		-0.1
Cauca	7.7	2580		2244	7.9	2572		2287		-0.2
Cesar	8.3	2224		1717	8.0	1833		1510		0.3
Chocó	7.6	857		754	7.9	1016		913		-0.3
Cundinamarca	8.1	3818		3322	7.8	4233		3684		0.3
Córdoba	8.1	2706		2240	8.0	2226		1933		0.1
Guainía	7.7	327		273	7.4	350		274		0.3
Guaviare	8.2	700		457	8.0	621		411		0.2
Huila	8.1	2961		2322	8.0	2999		2407		0.1
La Guajira	8.2	951		750	7.9	988		736		0.3
Magdalena	8.2	2458		2096	8.0	2110		1710		0.2
Meta	8.2	3683		2752	8.1	3862		2817		0.1
Nariño	7.7	2284		2034	7.4	2847		2492		0.3
Norte de Santander	8.3	2499		2028	8.2	2587		2171		0.1
Putumayo	8.0	950		752	7.6	1272		1012		0.4
Quindío	8.2	2085		1658	8.4	2186		1785		-0.2
Risaralda	8.4	1634		1353	8.3	1996		1663		0.1
San Andrés y Providencia	8.4	28		25	8.2	29		26		0.2
Santander	8.4	3790		3194	8.0	4153		3574		0.4
Sucre	7.9	1798		1399	7.8	1899		1467		0.1
Tolima	8.1	3564		3215	8.0	4257		3770		0.1
Valle del Cauca	8.1	4892		4093	8.1	5268		4421		0
Vaupés	8.3	265		245	7.6	288		267		0.7
Vichada	7.8	515		455	7.6	584		482		0.2

5.2 Cities/Municipalities

Table 3: Life satisfaction by department.

municipality name	mean life satisfaction 2023	non-ing miss-life satisfaction 2023	mean life satisfaction 2021	non-ing miss-life satisfaction 2021	2023-2021 diff
Buga	NaN	NaN	8.0	215	NaN
Espinal	NaN	NaN	7.8	220	NaN
Mariquita	NaN	NaN	7.9	201	NaN
Ocaña	NaN	NaN	8.2	200	NaN
San Vicente del Caguán	NaN	NaN	8.1	240	NaN
Armenia	8.1	668.0	8.5	681	-0.4
Buenaventura	8.1	412.0	8.3	279	-0.2
Cartagena	8.2	591.0	8.4	572	-0.2
Facatativá	8.1	200.0	8.3	222	-0.2
Palмира	7.9	319.0	8.1	332	-0.2
Popayán	7.9	225.0	8.1	232	-0.2
Tuluá	8.2	303.0	8.4	307	-0.2
Tunja	7.9	270.0	8.1	241	-0.2
Cali	8.0	985.0	8.1	1108	-0.1
Pitalito	8.0	293.0	8.1	288	-0.1
Cúcuta	8.3	573.0	8.3	553	0.0
Manizales	8.4	462.0	8.4	567	0.0
Medellín	8.4	905.0	8.4	959	0.0
Puerto Carreño	7.5	225.0	7.5	215	0.0
San José del Guaviare	8.1	246.0	8.1	231	0.0
Villavicencio	8.2	982.0	8.2	990	0.0
Acacías	8.3	229.0	8.2	233	0.1
Bogotá, D.C.	8.2	3446.0	8.1	3836	0.1
Calarcá	8.4	244.0	8.3	257	0.1
Pereira	8.4	524.0	8.3	677	0.1
Santa Marta	8.3	225.0	8.2	218	0.1
Sincelejo	8.1	222.0	8.0	275	0.1
Valledupar	8.0	339.0	7.9	274	0.1
Barranquilla	8.3	1363.0	8.1	1116	0.2
Florencia	8.2	575.0	8.0	630	0.2
Ibagué	8.4	478.0	8.2	549	0.2
Pasto	7.9	244.0	7.7	309	0.2
Yopal	8.3	264.0	8.1	240	0.2
Montería	8.3	465.0	8.0	372	0.3
Neiva	8.3	417.0	8.0	436	0.3
Riosucio	8.5	203.0	8.2	203	0.3
Sogamoso	8.2	236.0	7.9	367	0.3
Aguachica	8.6	202.0	8.1	215	0.5
Bucaramanga	8.6	798.0	8.1	842	0.5
Ciénaga	8.4	234.0	7.9	252	0.5
Magangué	8.3	205.0	7.8	207	0.5

5.3 Urban-Rural and Farmers

Colombia is quite urbanized at around 70-80%. <https://population.un.org/wup/countryprofiles?country=Colombia&mainCategory=Countries%20and%20Aggregates&subCategory=Urbanization%20-%20International%20definition>

Still, a substantial part at 20-30% is rural.

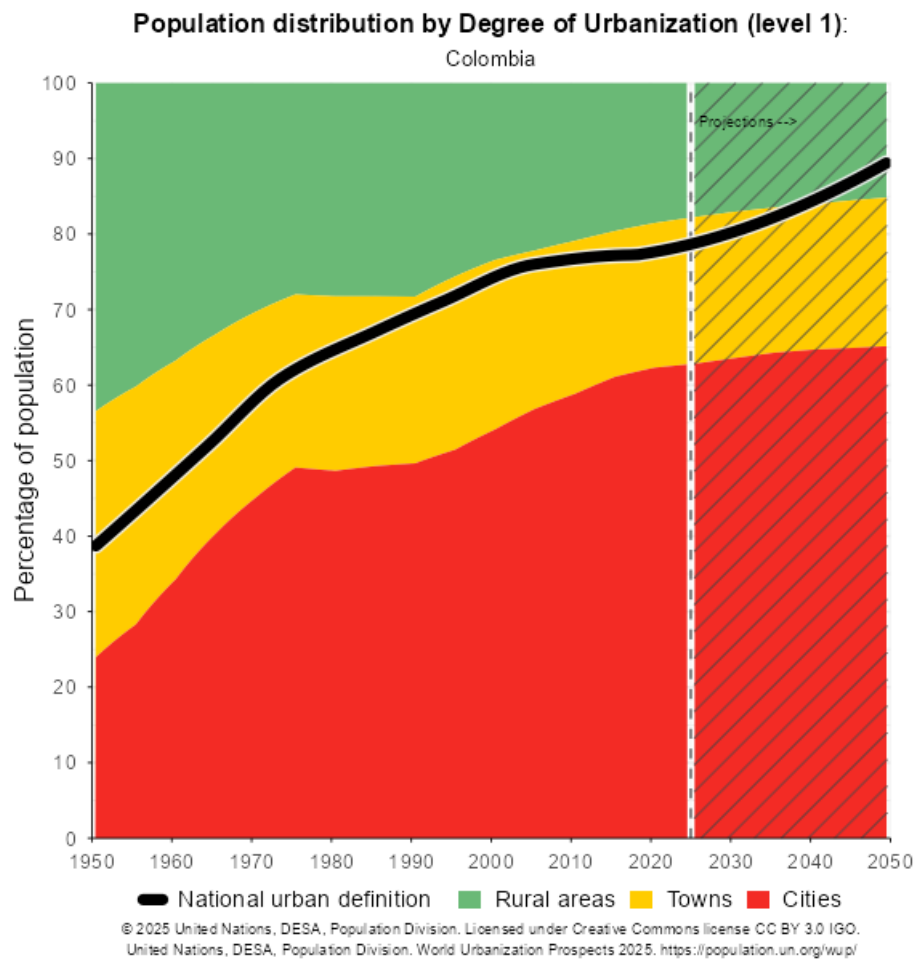


Figure 5

References

- GLAESER, E. (2011): *Triumph of the City: How Our Greatest Invention Makes Us Richer, Smarter, Greener, Healthier, and Happier*, Penguin Press, New York NY.
- GRAHAM, C. (2009): *Happiness around the world: The paradox of happy peasants and miserable millionaires*, Oxford University Press, New York NY.
- OKULICZ-KOZARYN, A. AND R. R. VALENTE (2021): "Urban unhappiness is common," *Cities*, 103368.
- O'SULLIVAN, A. (2009): *Urban economics*, McGraw-Hill.